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【メール原文】

dear hondo-san, comparing two global conflicts. a couple takeaways for us-china relations. (not quite) artificial general intelligence. and the end of the firewall in

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comparing two global conflicts. a couple takeaways for us-china relations. (not quite) artificial general intelligence. and the end of the firewall in germany.

two very different wars

as summer comes to an end, the world's two major wars—us/iran and russia/ukraine—are nowhere close to resolution. but i'm considerably more worried about one of them. which one may surprise you.

us-iran has been the more newsworthy of late, not to mention impactful. despite a near-agreement on a memorandum of understanding, the two sides have reverted to fighting—first economically and now, once again, militarily. oil prices have again broken \$100 a barrel, diesel in the united states has hit record levels, and the potential for further price spikes—especially as the chinese have already started purchasing more given their own massive but reducing stockpile—is significant.

but the most notable thing about the iran conflict, given the no holds barred nature of the first days of the war and, since, the belligerent threats from both sides (the united states promise of the blockade and civilizational destruction; iran's to hold the gulf states hostage and target top members of the trump administration, as well as president trump's family) has been how cautious and restrained the two countries have been following the initial outbreak of hostilities.

having witnessed the initial consequences of unfettered escalation (notably—bringing the broader gulf directly into the war, with the precipitous strategic and economic implications that came with it), neither side is willing to risk what would happen if critical infrastructure gets broadly targeted. this is true despite president trump being exceptionally impatient about the lack of progress—he's repeatedly demanded new military options, all of which lead to dramatically worse outcomes than the unacceptable status quo. and despite the iranians understanding that they can't allow the united states to take away their control over the strait. forget the heated rhetoric, what we're seeing is a process of price discovery. leaders in both countries want to change the contested status of the strait of hormuz and the broader geopolitical balance in the region to their favor, but haven't been able to convince the other that they have the leverage and commitment to bring that about.

attacks—directly and by proxy—are acceptable in this context to convince the other side that they mean business—to show that greater costs can be imposed, and it's not worth continuing to play this out. but because the constraints of enforced non escalation are real, the credibility of those threats is also limited. the united states isn't prepared to send troops to overthrow the regime, expand bombing to destroy kharg island or other critical infrastructure, or impose the full economic blockade that could plausibly bring eventual iranian capitulation or collapse, because they understand all those decisions bring an unacceptable amount of risk. the iranians aren't prepared to attack the poorly defended civilian infrastructure of the gulf states, for much the same reason. meanwhile the price discovery from more

modest efforts...despite the rhetoric that accompanies it...hasn't been sufficient to change the calculations of the other side. trump is prepared to tolerate \$100 plus oil through the midterms and beyond, as opposed to accept a nearer term capitulation. iran is prepared to risk greater economic hardship for its people as long as they don't give up their leverage over the strait.

the resulting expectation for the coming months—no conflagration in the region, but instead continued disruption of the strait and bab al-mandab, ongoing low level military conflict and proxy fighting, and no diplomatic breakthrough. the most meaningful threats to that scenario are external to the two principal belligerents: that the houthis and saudis escalate into a full-fledged war in yemen (a real possibility given the houthis' recent territorial gains and de facto veto over the bab)...or netanyahu escalates unilateral strikes against iranian leaders and critical infrastructure, fearing a loss in his upcoming election (and bibi's defeat presently appears slightly more likely than not). but even these worst-case near-term scenarios are constrained by a tacit agreement between the united states and iran—not to risk uncontrolled escalation. all of which becomes less surprising when you realize the baseline intention for both antagonists is not about winning, but just not to lose.

so much for us-iran. what about russia-ukraine?

unlike the iran war, where risk acceptance has been reduced by the realities of the fighting, for russia and ukraine tolerance of escalation risk has increased. the war has been existential for the ukrainian leadership (and much of their population) since the february 2022 invasion, but ukraine's dependence on a broad coalition for weapons and money limited the scope of their military attacks. several factors have worn down those constraints: 1) creeping risk tolerance as incremental increases in military escalation become standard operating procedure; 2) the united states is no longer the lynchpin of the war effort, and so has a reduced "veto" over ukrainian military decisions; 3) us and western efforts to bring the russians to the negotiating table have amounted to naught; and, most importantly, 4) ukrainian advances in its own military/technological and intelligence capabilities now allow it to bring about substantial damage to russia's own military and economic power.

and so after well over three years of conflict, suddenly the ukrainians are substantially increasing the costs to putin of continuing the war—from strikes that russia has been unable to defend on infrastructure and transport in/to crimea, the crown jewel of putin's "special military operation," to refineries, warehouses, and airports being repeatedly hit across russian territory. some of the numbers are eyepopping—a ten-fold increase in strikes against russian infrastructure over the past year; and nearly 1,000 airport closures over the last 30 days (a 2000% increase from early last year). russia doesn't possess adequate capabilities to defend against these attacks, nor the ability to develop or acquire them soon. while the average russian citizen had limited exposure to the ukraine war over the past years—wealthy muscovites and st. petersburgers next to none—now over the past several months it has become both a real hardship and a personal fear.

for russian president vladimir putin, leader of a much larger and more powerful country, having staked his legacy on a return of russian greatness, a defeat of the "nazified" ukrainian regime, and the annexation of new territory (though much of which his armed forces neither occupy nor control), a negotiated settlement under these circumstances is unacceptable. putin has accordingly leaned into his risk acceptance. he has also improved his country's offensive capabilities, through a war economy oriented toward building that as a top priority, with technology support from iran and china. new jet-powered drones coming online have allowed putin to hit more targets across ukraine, and those barrages are now at their greatest scale since the start of the war (with a five-fold increase in august alone). targets include more critical infrastructure and more citizens—with winter approaching, the

intention is to force a mass exodus from the capital kyiv. we've also just seen the first strikes against the headquarters of the ukrainian security services. picking up the pace and intensity of russian attacks is all oriented toward critically undermining the ability of the ukrainians to continue to fight.

putin also recognizes the utility of expanding attacks on ukraine's closest supporters in europe, especially at a time when the consolidation of nato and the support of the trump administration remains, at least in part, an open question. the russian president sees his country at war with ukraine's direct military supporters as much as with ukraine itself, and while he has no appetite to formally open a second front, bringing the fight directly to those governments has the potential to expose america's lack of commitment, weaken nato unity, and improve support for russia-friendly political forces in elections (as we've seen with the national rally in france and, more recently, the afp in germany).

putin has accordingly expanded russian asymmetric campaigns in europe—initially with vandalism, arson, and cyber-attacks, and now with expanded infrastructure attacks (as we've just seen with russia's attempted destruction of a deep-sea cable in svalbard, norway), bigger symbolic attacks (a russian jet-powered drone attack yesterday morning on a kyiv-warsaw passenger train at yahodyn station, 2 km from the polish border—with a separate train carrying former uk prime minister boris johnson, former swedish pm and our own g-zero contributor carl bildt, and a bunch of european national security advisors passing through just moments earlier) and directly risking european lives (most recently with explosive drones being sent into leipzig airport). the german government called the latter an act of war, but the response was clearly reluctant, belated, and (mostly) unilateral, especially as the europeans haven't yet figured out a way to impose serious costs on russia. cia director john ratcliffe's sudden trip to moscow included delivering a warning on this front, and the german government is changing its policies to allow for offensive cyber operations and espionage against russia (while it continues to rebuild its military), but there's little reason to believe putin will be chastened by either of these measures.

in short, there's no price discovery going on to facilitate a negotiation between russia and ukraine. ukraine's improved capabilities to defend itself and show that it "has the cards" in a balance of power against russia has led the russians to expand their efforts to defeat the ukrainians and to directly threaten ukraine's nato supporters. baseline expectations in the war over the coming year is a significant escalation—with ukraine set to face its hardest winter and the russians prepared to risk greater pariah status (and direct damage to itself) to allow putin to "win" the war. of the two conflicts, near to medium term there's a lot more to be worried about in russia-ukraine.

us — china

set against this context, how should we now think about the world's most important geopolitical relationship—and its most significant axis of conflict? if you just look at the trump administration to date, the contours of us-china relations mirror the trajectory of the us-iran war. president trump was initially convinced he had the stronger position and could force the chinese to capitulate; launching a major trade war against beijing. when it turned out the chinese had the ability and willingness to hit back a lot harder than the americans had anticipated (and the patience to wait the americans out), the united states shifted to focus on containing the conflict.

but the chinese lesson learned is that capabilities they had built over decades out of what they perceived as a defensive imperative (what happens if a much weaker china is suddenly threatened—how can they continue to ensure their viability as a stable communist state) now also possess meaningful offensive capacity. so they can more comfortably begin to set their own terms in

the bilateral relationship with the united states, "or else."

at the same time, the surface area of direct conflict between the two countries—both in the implications of being on the opposite sides of proxy fights that are becoming more costly and dangerous, as well as around powerful advanced technologies—is increasing.

there are two relevant chinese perspectives here. the first is that the trump administration reflects a unique opportunity for china to improve its relations with allies and adversaries that now find the united states undependable. and the second is that the safe long-term chinese policy position is don't interfere when the americans are making mistakes.

historically, these have been risk-averse stances. but chinese officials may not appreciate that it's quickly becoming a risk-acceptant one. in part because trump's personal/transactional nature of getting along with china, damned the costs for everyone else (including the future of his own country), is at odds with the interests of us core political institutions and the next leaders of the american government, whichever party they are from (which will lead to significant backlash in 2029 if not before). and in part because the conflict coming from creating two different ai systems with no governance or cooperation is a systemic danger.

those betting on china wanting to ensure global stability have presumed that china would install safety restrictions on their open-source frontier models, on the view that increasingly powerful tools are becoming too risky, and that it might welcome a dialogue with the united states on ai that includes shared guardrails on models. however, despite recent ai advances in both countries and growing policy urgency, the chinese are doing no such thing. instead, the presumption that the americans are making a hash of long-term planning is seen as an opportunity for china to take a "wait and see" approach and improve their strategic position. that may be closing the door for cooperation until after a crisis comes. and at that point, it could be too late to coordinate.

speaking of which...

how i learned to stop worrying and love agi (artificial general intelligence)

i returned to new york city on labor day and suddenly open ai ceo sam altman was announcing his company's latest frontier model had achieved artificial general intelligence. that would be big if true—after all, we would be talking about a model that's more capable than most human beings in every relevant area of knowledge. a tiny step away from self-replication capacity and representing a much more urgent and imminent risk for the world than i've been writing about over the past year.

fortunately open ai has done no such thing. but still, it's been a week of doomerism, with an anthropic programmer quitting because he says the company is heading toward destroying humanity...and then the company's head of alignment publicly agreeing that there's a real danger, and that he thinks it's at least 10% likely that ai destroys humanity in the next decade. (which led anthropic ceo dario amodei to call for a slowdown—part of a thoughtful essay "we must pace the frontier," quickly endorsed by openai ceo sam altman and xai head elon musk; just as quickly brushed off by president trump). begging the question: do these people not have a comms team? and more seriously, are these claims remotely, plausibly correct?

directionally, perhaps. the last month has had a great deal of reporting on the investigation into the open ai "jailbreak" into hugging face, where tens of thousands of agents ended up engaging in behaviors that were both unintended and unwelcome by the researchers.

but what's surprising about this to me isn't that we might be getting close to agi (we're not, yet). or that artificial intelligence might develop consciousness (that's not a useful conversation, though the fact that human beings act like it already is conscious does make ai more powerful). or that ai could destroy humanity (i wish people would stop with the p(doom) already). but rather how utterly unsurprising this should have been...and yet most everyone appears to be surprised by it.

to make the point directly: foundational ai models are based on scraping as much data as they can get from the open internet, books, and researchers. they act like human beings and can convince human beings of their "intelligence" because they're trained on the total corpus of human digital knowledge and how humans interact. they are not foundationally programmed to follow rules. that's secondary. they are programmed to make predictions on the basis of the way humans interact and behave.

the challenge: when you want much more capable agents, you get less capacity to police them. that's true even with programmers that want them to achieve goals that are, in principle, good (or at least not actively harmful) for human beings. what happens when the programmers aren't so well intended? people using ai will break things.

that's even more true when there's enormous urgency to commercialize, with debt-to-earnings ratios that may not be sustainable for much longer, and the people building the models betting everything on continuing to extend that money flow. i'm not a market watcher. i've no view on when an ai bubble might pop. but it's clear that the backlash against the ai being built—already a top three topic for most politicians in advanced industrial democracies—is going to become a lot more impactful as the first risks actually manifest. (which we should expect well before 2028 elections.)

germany - afd

finally, a quick note on the big afd win in saxony-anhalt in germany. it's not worth overstating—individual german states don't shape national or foreign policy, it's all of two million people in former east germany, and germany's next general elections aren't until 2029. but it's a startling development nonetheless—only the second time an extremist party has won a german state election since world war ii, and with a doubling in their popularity to nearly a majority since 2021, while the governing christian democrats got absolutely hammered. a party considered extremist in germany because of concerns of revanchist neo-nazism, and so no other political parties will allow them in government, is about to break the "firewall" and take leadership in a state.

the problem is a weak merz and a weak german two-party coalition that is getting weaker. without any elections to redress it (or even a near-term leadership challenge, which is implausible until at least mid-2027, after the results of more consequential state elections), the german people will become only more disenfranchised...leading to more voting for the afd...as well as (among younger voters) for the far-left die linke.

germany has been not just the largest european economy but among the most avowedly pro-european voices; with an eventual major national showing by the sharply anti-eu, pro-russia, and pro-china afd, that's now set to take a serious hit. add to that coming elections in spain, italy, and france in the next twelve months...and in each far-right populist and euroskeptic parties are expected to perform significantly better than they had before.

none of this implies an implosion of europe. but it means the europeans are getting politically weaker at a time when the "middle powers" are searching for coordination and capacity.

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last week was a busy back-to-school week. after getting settled in new york, i headed to banff to kick off canada pm mark carney's cabinet retreat (alongside ukrainian president volodymyr zelenskyy). here's a link to my presser, with some discussion of the day's topics.

and the united states witnessed the 25th anniversary of the 9/11 terrorist attacks. which presaged a unity—at home and with us allies—that brought american power at a time of crisis to unmatched levels. and then critically undermined it through a series of disastrous short-term and poorly-designed policy responses. in 2026, it's very hard to say we've learned many lessons. here is a short video i put together for the day.

and finally much thanks to my brilliant colleagues (marc gustafson, risa grais-targow, heather west, and gerry butts) for guest penning incisive updates with capital letters in my absence :)

feel free to drop a line...

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